FOGGS Open Consultation #7:

THE ROLE OF "MIDDLE POWERS" AND CITIZENS IN BALANCING THE INTERNATIONAL SYSTEM

Monday, 7 April 2025, 3:00 pm – 4:30 pm Brussels time (online)

Event Summary

The session began with a cordial welcome by Georgios Kostakos, the Executive Director of FOGGS – the Foundation for Global Governance Sustainability. Georgios outlined the organization's core commitment to addressing current global challenges through the lens of multilateralism, sustainable development, and a reinvigorated approach to global citizenship. He emphasized the need for a new narrative on globalization—one that is inclusive, promotes active global citizenship, and supports sustainable prosperity and resilience to shocks. Georgios also introduced the main points of a presentation on the same topic that he had made on 26 March 2025 at the Africa Consultative Meeting 2025 hosted by the Inclusive Society Institute (ISI) in Cape Town, South Africa.

- Critique of dominant global powers

The discussion then moved to an examination of the prevailing international system. Participants critiqued the longstanding dominance of major powers, whose geopolitical rivalries and unilateral strategies have often overshadowed collective global interests. They explained that these traditional power centers, by pursuing narrow, self-interested agendas, not only fuel polarization but also exacerbate global inequalities. This part of the discussion underscored the persistent systemic imbalance in international affairs, where the influence of a few major states can skew the rules and institutions meant to govern global interactions.

- Rise and role of the "middle powers"

A key focus of the consultation was the emergence on the international stage of influential "middle powers" from both the Global South and the Global North, such as (in alphabetical order) Brazil, Canada, Indonesia, Mexico, Norway, Singapore and South Africa. Although the definition of what constitutes a "middle power" varies, participants discussed how states broadly categorized as such are increasingly assuming, individually or collectively, the role of stabilizers and mediators in international relations. They explored how middle powers are attempting to redefine global power/influence, by employing methods like coalition-building, strategic autonomy and niche diplomacy. The discussion highlighted that while these countries may lack the overwhelming military or economic might of the great powers, their diplomatic maneuvers and willingness to engage multilaterally can introduce a more balanced and cooperative dynamic to global affairs. A key element that such countries need

to bring is a clear vision of a better future and inspiring, wise leadership, which apparently is in very short supply today across the world.

- The influence of citizen diplomacy and grassroots movements
In parallel with the discussion on middle powers, the event paid considerable attention to the impact of citizen-led initiatives and grassroots diplomacy. Participants noted that transnational citizen movements—ranging from climate activists to digital rights advocates and humanitarian networks—are emerging as influential players in global politics. These movements are seen as a counterweight to entrenched state power, challenging established hierarchies through advocacy, public engagement, and moral authority. The conversation emphasized that these non-state actors help hold both governments and international institutions accountable, thereby introducing fresh perspectives into debates on governance and public policy.

- Potential and pitfalls of rebalancing the global order
A recurring theme in the discussion was the critical question of whether the combined force of middle powers and citizen diplomacy can effectively rebalance a system that remains structurally biased toward a few dominant states. Participants elaborated on both the promise and the limitations inherent in this evolving paradigm. They cautioned that while emerging powers and grassroots initiatives have the potential to foster a more inclusive global order, they might also be constrained by the existing institutional framework or even co-opted by the very power structures they seek to challenge. This discussion brought out the tension between transformative aspirations and the pragmatic challenges of effecting systemic change.

- Addressing gaps in global governance
The consultation delved into specific global governance challenges, where collaboration between middle powers and global civil society might make a significant difference. Topics such as pandemic preparedness, artificial intelligence regulation, and debt relief were discussed as critical areas that currently suffer from fragmented responses. Participants argued that a cooperative approach involving both state actors and citizen initiatives is essential to bridge these gaps. However, they also warned that without careful coordination, these efforts could inadvertently replicate existing global or regional hierarchies, including in the provenance of, outlook of and resources available to civil society organizations, or devolve into transactional relationships rather than genuinely transformative partnerships.

- Institutional adaptation and future directions
Looking ahead, the conversation turned to how traditional international institutions like the United Nations and the G20 might evolve to better incorporate the voices and innovative practices of middle powers and grassroots movements. Participants called for institutional reforms that do not simply absorb these emerging forces into established processes but rather amplify their capacity to instigate change. This part of the discussion underscored the need for a recalibrated international order—one that is more inclusive, agile, and responsive to the challenges of the 21st century. Significant importance was assigned by several participants to the need to reform the UN Security Council, including proposals to expand the Council's membership with new seats for middle powers from all continents, those seats being permanent or non-permanent but longer-term and renewable.

- Some overall thoughts and call to reflect and engage further

Throughout the session, the participants were encouraged to critically reflect on the implications of ongoing shifts in global power dynamics and opportunities opening up to promote peace, sustainable development and human rights. Concerns were expressed about global governance reform initiatives emanating from or inspired by the Trump Administration, see "DOGE UN", and how they should be handled. The role of the private sector and the media needed particular attention if we would like to empower global citizens rather than continue to focus on shareholders. Academics and researchers should break free from external and self-imposed censorship. Several questions remained on the role and possible effectiveness of middle powers in revitalizing the United Nations, including functions like peacekeeping, and supporting and expanding the role of international courts. A new, positive and hopeful narrative of global cooperation is urgently needed and should be worked out with the participation of all concerned. In closing, participants urged ongoing dialogue and active engagement by all relevant actors to drive meaningful change in global governance.

Summary produced with AI assistance.
Complete video recording is available here.